

ONE-PAGE CHEAT SHEET

Wi-Fi, Zigbee or Bluetooth?

You don't need the engineering. You need to know what each option costs you in setup and in reliability.

	Wi-Fi	Zigbee	Bluetooth
NEEDS A HUB?	No. Connects straight to your router.	Yes. A Zigbee hub or gateway, sold separately.	No. Pairs with your phone.
BEST FOR	Plugs, bulbs, cameras, doorbells	Small battery sensors: doors, leaks, motion. Larger homes.	LED strips, projectors, speakers, simple lights
RANGE	Your router's coverage	Mesh: mains-powered devices relay the signal	About one room. Walls reduce it.
POWER	Mains or battery (batteries drain faster)	Very low. Coin-cell batteries can last a long time.	Low
WATCH OUT	Usually 2.4 GHz only. Dozens of devices can crowd a basic router.	The hub is an extra purchase. Check the hub supports the device.	Remote control and voice usually need a gateway or a Wi-Fi bridge.

Which one should you start with?

Do you already own a Zigbee hub, or a speaker with one built in?

Yes: Zigbee sensors are a good fit.
No: start with Wi-Fi devices. If a product is Zigbee-only, factor the hub into your budget.

How many smart devices in 6 months?

1 to 5: Wi-Fi is enough.
6 to 15: Wi-Fi, but watch your router.
16 or more: consider a Zigbee hub for small sensors.

Will you control things away from home?

Yes: pick Wi-Fi devices, or Zigbee through a hub. Bluetooth alone usually will not reach you outside the house.
No: Bluetooth is fine for single-room lights.

Four words you will see

2.4 GHz

The Wi-Fi band most smart devices use. Many cannot join 5 GHz.

Mesh

Devices passing the signal along to each other, so range grows as you add mains-powered ones.

Hub / gateway

A small box that talks to Zigbee devices and connects them to your network.

Routine

A saved rule, like "lights on at sunset", that runs on its own.

Safety alarms are different. Smoke, carbon monoxide and gas alarms protect lives. Buy only UL-listed units (UL 217 for smoke, UL 2034 for carbon monoxide) from established brands. We do not sell them, on purpose.